

2) 2nd question from endsem

The argument states that human beings are not things and therefore should never be treated merely as means to an end. Every human being must be respected as an end in itself, and human life is inviolable. This means that no person can be sacrificed against their will, even for a good purpose such as saving others. The important ethical question is: when does this inviolability begin? The argument claims that it cannot depend on age or stage of development. Since infants clearly deserve moral respect and every infant once existed as an embryo, embryos too must be morally protected from the beginning.

This argument is based on the idea of continuity. Human development from conception to adulthood is a continuous biological process. There is no exact moment where a non-person suddenly becomes a person. If we choose birth, viability, or consciousness as the starting point of personhood, that choice may seem arbitrary. Because there is no clear dividing line, many people argue that moral protection should begin at conception itself. If this is true, abortion becomes morally wrong because it destroys a being that already has a right to life.

This view is strong because it protects innocent human life. It avoids judging moral worth based on age, intelligence, or physical development. If adults and infants deserve rights because they are human beings, embryos may also deserve the same respect since they are simply the earliest stage of human life. This gives powerful support to anti-abortion arguments.

However, I would respond by questioning whether biological humanity alone is enough for full moral personhood. Simply being biologically human may not automatically mean having the same moral rights as a fully developed person. Judith Jarvis Thomson explains this in her essay *A Defense of Abortion*. She argues that even if we assume the fetus is a person from conception, it does not automatically follow that abortion is always morally wrong.

Thomson uses the famous “violinist” example. Imagine waking up and finding yourself connected to an unconscious violinist who needs your kidneys to survive. If you disconnect, he will die, but if you remain connected for nine months, he will recover. Even though the violinist is clearly a person with a right to life, most people would say you are not morally required to keep supporting him with your body. Helping him would be generous, but not morally compulsory.

This shows that a right to life does not automatically include the right to use another person’s body. Thomson applies this to pregnancy, especially in cases of rape. If a woman did not consent to pregnancy, forcing her to continue it may be morally similar to forcing someone to remain attached to the violinist. Therefore, even if the fetus is a person, abortion may still be morally permissible because bodily autonomy also matters.

The same reasoning applies when the mother’s life is in danger. If both mother and fetus are persons with equal right to life, it is unfair to demand that only the mother must sacrifice

herself. A woman has the right to defend her own life, even if that results in the death of the fetus.

In conclusion, embryos deserve moral consideration because they represent developing human life, but this does not necessarily mean they have exactly the same inviolability as born persons. Respect for women's autonomy, consent, and life must also be considered. Ethics should balance both the value of fetal life and the rights of the mother rather than giving complete priority to only one side.

Question 5 – Explain Rawls' Theory of Justice and discuss the Original Position, Veil of Ignorance, and Two Principles of Justice

John Rawls' theory of justice, presented in *A Theory of Justice*, is one of the most important modern theories in political philosophy. Rawls explains justice through the idea of "justice as fairness." According to him, a just society is one where the basic structure of institutions is arranged fairly so that every individual receives equal moral consideration. His aim was to create principles of justice that free and rational people would choose if they were placed in a fair and equal situation .

Rawls introduces the concept of the **Original Position**, which is a hypothetical situation used to determine fair principles of justice. In this position, all individuals are considered equal and rational, and they must choose the rules that will govern society. However, they make these choices under a **Veil of Ignorance**. This means that no one knows their future place in society—their class, wealth, gender, religion, intelligence, talents, or social status .

Because of this ignorance, people cannot make selfish decisions to benefit themselves. Since they do not know whether they will be rich or poor, strong or weak, privileged or disadvantaged, they will choose principles that are fair for everyone. This creates impartiality and ensures justice. Rawls says that justice must be based on fairness, not personal advantage.

From this original position, Rawls believes people would choose **Two Principles of Justice**.

The **First Principle** is the principle of equal basic liberty. It states that each person has an equal right to the most extensive system of basic liberties compatible with similar liberties for others . These liberties include freedom of thought, liberty of conscience, political liberty, freedom of speech, freedom of association, freedom from slavery, freedom of movement, and rights protected by the rule of law. Rawls gives this principle the highest priority because liberty is essential for human dignity and self-respect.

The **Second Principle** deals with social and economic inequalities. Rawls accepts that complete equality may not always be possible, but inequalities are justified only under two conditions. First, positions and offices must be open to all under conditions of fair equality of opportunity. This means everyone should have a genuine chance to succeed, not just formal

equality. Second, inequalities must work to the greatest benefit of the least advantaged members of society . This is called the **Difference Principle**.

For example, if doctors earn more money than others, this inequality is acceptable only if society as a whole benefits, especially the poor and disadvantaged. If inequality only helps the rich and increases injustice, it is morally unacceptable.

Rawls also gives priority to liberty over economic benefit. He says equal personal liberty cannot be sacrificed simply to increase wealth or improve economic distribution. Basic freedoms must be protected first, even if limiting them could produce more material benefits .

Amartya Sen criticizes Rawls by saying that his theory gives too much importance to ideal institutions rather than actual social realities. Rawls focuses on perfect justice, while Sen emphasizes how justice is actually experienced in society. Sen distinguishes between **Niti** (rules and institutions) and **Nyaya** (realized justice in practice). He argues that equal access to resources does not always mean equal opportunity because people have different abilities to use those resources.

In conclusion, Rawls' theory of justice is based on fairness, equality, and protection of liberty. Through the Original Position and Veil of Ignorance, he creates a method for choosing just principles without bias. His Two Principles of Justice aim to balance liberty and equality while protecting the least advantaged. Even though critics like Amartya Sen challenge some assumptions, Rawls' theory remains one of the strongest foundations for modern discussions of justice.

8a) abortion

Abortion is one of the most debated issues in moral philosophy because it involves a conflict between two important rights: the right to life of the fetus and the right of the woman to control her own body. The ethical question is whether abortion is morally permissible, and if so, under what conditions. Different philosophers answer this differently depending on how they understand personhood, rights, and moral responsibility.

A common anti-abortion argument begins with the claim that the fetus is a human being, or a person, from the moment of conception. Since every person has a right to life, the fetus also has a right to life. Therefore, abortion is considered morally wrong because it involves killing an innocent person . Supporters of this view argue that human development from conception to birth is a continuous process, and choosing one exact point where personhood begins is arbitrary. If there is no clear dividing line, moral protection should begin from conception itself.

This argument is strong because it protects innocent life. If the fetus is treated as a full person, abortion may seem equal to murder. Many people therefore conclude that abortion is always morally impermissible, except perhaps when the mother's life is in danger.

However, Judith Jarvis Thomson challenges this conclusion in her essay *A Defense of Abortion*. She argues that even if we assume the fetus is a person from conception, abortion does not automatically become morally wrong. The main issue is not only whether the fetus is a person, but whether it has the right to use the mother's body.

Thomson explains this using the famous "violinist" thought experiment. Imagine waking up in a hospital and finding yourself connected to an unconscious violinist who has a fatal kidney disease. Only your body can keep him alive. If you disconnect, he will die, but if you remain connected for nine months, he will recover. You were kidnapped and did not consent to this arrangement. Thomson asks whether you are morally required to stay connected.

Most people would say that although helping the violinist would be kind and generous, you are not morally obligated to do so. You have the right to decide what happens to your own body. Thomson uses this example to show that even if the violinist has a right to life, he does not automatically have the right to use your body without your consent.

She applies this argument to pregnancy, especially in cases of rape. If a woman becomes pregnant without consent, forcing her to continue the pregnancy may be morally similar to forcing someone to remain attached to the violinist. Therefore, abortion may be morally permissible because the fetus's right to life does not always outweigh the woman's bodily autonomy.

Thomson also rejects the "extreme view" that abortion is wrong even when continuing the pregnancy will kill the mother. If both mother and fetus are persons with equal right to life, it is unreasonable to expect only the mother to sacrifice herself. A woman has the right to defend her own life, even if doing so results in the death of the fetus.

In conclusion, abortion is morally complex because it involves conflicting rights. The fetus may have moral value and a right to life, but the woman also has rights over her own body, health, and future. Thomson shows that the right to life does not automatically include the right to use another person's body. Therefore, abortion can be morally permissible in many situations, especially in cases of rape or danger to the mother's life. Ethics requires balancing respect for both fetal life and women's autonomy.

8j) ethics of ai

The ethics of Artificial Intelligence (AI) focuses on whether AI systems can be considered moral agents and how they should be treated in human society. As AI becomes more advanced in areas like healthcare, finance, law, transport, and military systems, an important ethical question arises: can machines be moral agents like human beings, capable of right

and wrong actions? This idea is discussed through the concept of Artificial Moral Agency (AMA).

An entity has moral status if it counts morally in its own right, meaning it is morally right or wrong to do things to it for its own sake. Human beings have full moral status because they are treated not merely as means, but also as ends in themselves. Some philosophers argue that AI systems may also deserve moral consideration if they possess certain important qualities such as sentience and sapience.

Sentience means the capacity for conscious experience, such as feeling pain, pleasure, or suffering. Sapience refers to higher intelligence, such as self-awareness, rational thinking, and the ability to respond to reasons. According to this view, an AI system would have moral status only if it has both sentience and sapience. If a machine can think rationally and also experience consciousness, it may deserve moral respect similar to humans.

The debate about AMA mainly includes two views: the standard view and the functionalist view. Deborah Johnson supports the standard view. According to her, moral agency requires rationality, consciousness, free will, and internal mental states like beliefs and desires. She gives four conditions for moral agency: the entity must cause an action, have internal intentional states, these states must cause the action, and the action must have moral importance. Since AI systems do not truly possess beliefs, desires, or consciousness, Johnson argues they cannot be true moral agents.

On the other hand, Floridi and Sanders support the functionalist view. They argue that moral agency does not require consciousness, but only certain behaviors and responses. Their three conditions are interactivity, independence, and adaptability. Interactivity means the AI interacts with its environment. Independence means it can act without immediate human control. Adaptability means it can change its behavior based on experience. If a machine satisfies these conditions, it may be treated as a moral agent.

Another important idea is the Principle of Substrate Non-Discrimination. It says that if two beings have the same functionality and same conscious experience, but differ only in physical structure—one biological and one digital—they should have the same moral status. This means moral status should depend on capacities, not whether the being is made of flesh or silicon.

However, there are objections. Johnson's independence argument says that no matter how advanced AI becomes, it is still created by humans and depends on human intentions. Machines are products of human design, so responsibility should remain with the designers and users, not with the machine itself. For example, if a self-driving car causes harm, we usually blame the programmers or manufacturers, not the car.

In conclusion, AI ethics asks whether machines can be moral agents and how responsibility should be assigned. The standard view says AI lacks consciousness and cannot be true moral

agents, while the functionalist view focuses on behavior and allows the possibility of AMA. As AI becomes more powerful, this debate becomes more important. Even if AI may not yet deserve full moral status, society must carefully decide how much responsibility and moral recognition should be given to intelligent machines.